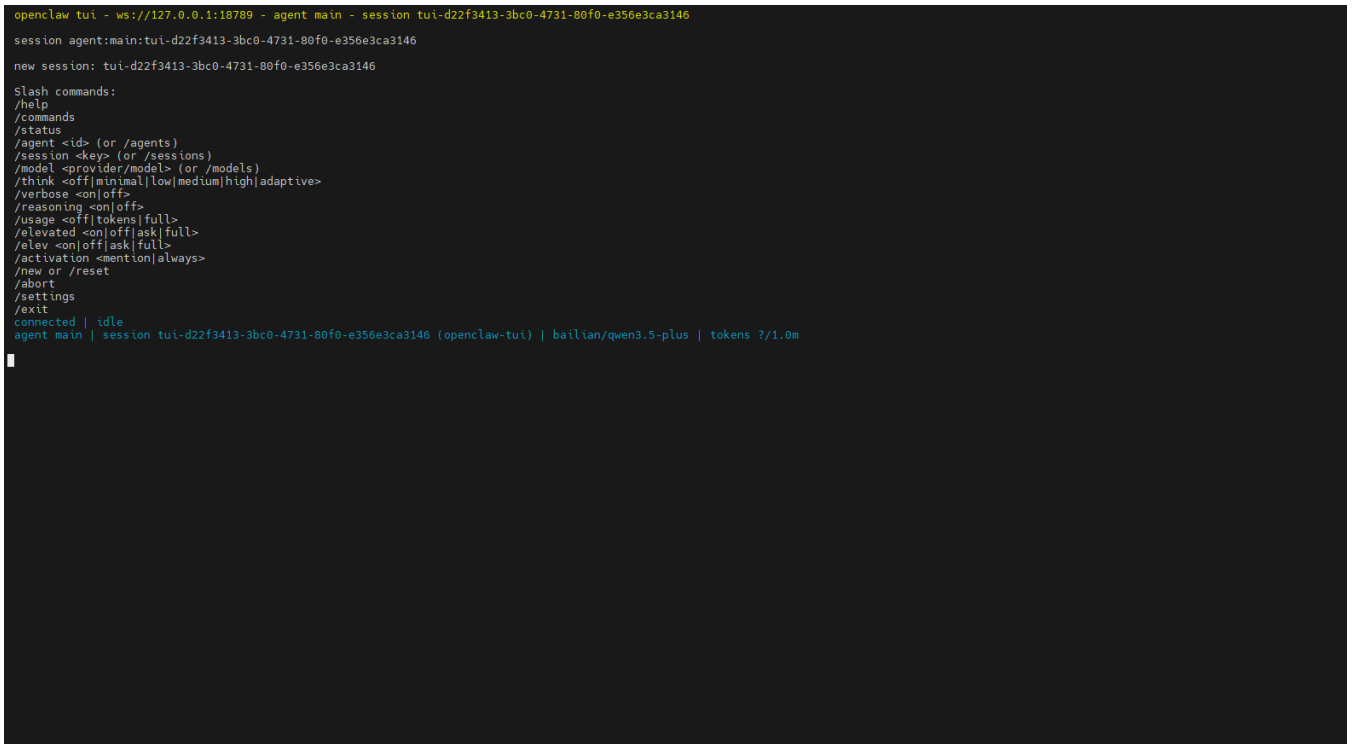
4. OpenClaw TUI Interaction

TUI (Text User Interface) is OpenClaw's "command line chat window". When it is not convenient for you to open the web console on the Jetson, or when you are connected remotely through SSH, the TUI lets you complete most of the daily interactions in the terminal: conversation, switching models, checking the status, managing sessions, calling skills, and so on.



1. How to Enter the TUI

Run the following in the terminal:

```
openclaw tui
```

If you have already started the OpenClaw gateway in another terminal (for example the gateway/server side), you can run `openclaw tui` directly to enter the interactive interface

For the non-Docker version, openclaw gateway does not need to be started manually; it starts automatically at boot

2. What the TUI Interface Is

You can understand the TUI as a "chat box with commands":

- Above: the conversation history (the messages you sent, the replies of the model, the tool/skill output)
- Below: the input box (where you enter a question or send a slash command)
- How to send: press Enter when you have finished typing

It is recommended to do two things the first time you enter:

```
/status
```

3. Slash Commands

A slash command normally has to be sent as a separate message that starts with `/`; it is used to control the session and to run the operations.

Command	Purpose	When to use it	Example
`/help`	View the help and the list of the commands	When you do not know which commands there are	`/help`
`/status`	View the current status	When you suspect it is not connected, or you want to see the context usage	`/status`
`/new`	Start a new conversation line (a new session)	When the topic changes, to avoid the context interference	`/new`
`/reset`	Reset the session (equivalent to starting over, the same effect as new)	When the conversation goes off track, or you want to clear the context	`/reset`
`/model` / `/models list`	View / switch the model	When you want a faster or a stronger model	`/models list`
`/think medium`	Set the thinking depth	For daily use, low or off is recommended	`/think medium`
`/stop`	Abort the current task	When it is stuck and you want to stop immediately	`/stop`
`/context detail`	View the context that is currently injected	To find out "why does it remember/forget certain things"	`/context detail`
`/compact`	Compress the earlier history into a summary	When the conversation is too long and the context is nearly full	`/compact`
`/skill <name>`	Run a certain skill	When you know the name of the skill and want to run it directly	`/skill web_search`

Two more "feel" suggestions for the daily use:

- Write only one slash command in one message, that is the safest
- To browse all the commands quickly, use `/help` or `/commands`

4. Session and Memory

In OpenClaw these two concepts have a very clear division of labour:

- Session: it manages "how far this conversation has got". When you use `/new` and `/reset` in the TUI, you are essentially switching or reopening the session.
- Memory: it manages "the content that should be kept for a long time across the sessions". It is written to

the disk (Markdown) and retrieved back into the current session when it is needed.

4.1 Where the Session Files Are

The sessions are saved on the disk in the JSONL format; the common locations are (take the actual installation path as the reference):

- The index: `~/.openclaw/agents/<agentId>/sessions/sessions.json`
- The transcripts: `~/.openclaw/agents/<agentId>/sessions/<SessionId>.jsonl`

The easier way when troubleshooting is to run the following first:

```
openclaw status
```

It usually gives the store path and the information about the recent sessions.

4.2 How to "Use" the Memory

You can understand the Memory as "letting the robot take notes":

- `memory/YYYY-MM-DD.md`: the log of each day, suitable for recording the progress and the temporary decisions
- `MEMORY.md`: the long term stable information (the preferences, the fixed rules, the project constraints and so on)

Practical suggestions:

- To make a conclusion usable across the sessions as well: simply tell the robot "write this into MEMORY.md"
- Before you prepare `/new` to switch to a new topic: first use `/compact` or write the key decisions into the Memory, and then switch the session

5. The Quick Start Flow

1. Enter the TUI: `openclaw tui`
2. Confirm the status: `/status`
3. Choose the model: `/models list` → `/model <the number or the name>`
4. Daily conversation: just type the question and press Enter
5. Switching the topic: `/new`
6. The context is too long: `/compact`
7. A key conclusion has to be kept for a long time: let the robot write it into the Memory

6. Troubleshooting the Common Problems

6.1 You entered a command but nothing happens

- Confirm that the command was sent on a line of its own (do not mix it with the ordinary text)
- Use `/help` first to see which commands the current version supports

6.2 You feel that "it starts talking nonsense, does not understand people" or that it is disturbed by the history

- Start a new session: `/new` or `/reset`
- Look at what is injected into the context: `/context detail`

6.3 The response gets slower and slower

- Lower the thinking depth: `/think low` or `/think minimal`
- Compress the history: `/compact`